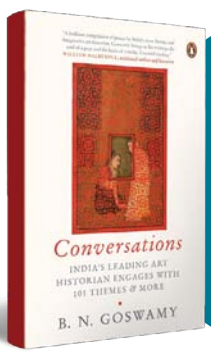
your response is "So what?"—well, imagine if we were discussing medicine. In addition, all of the previous contenders for the office indicated in the subtitle began as something else. A.K. Coomaraswamy—the subject of a glowing tribute here, tinged with indignation that he is not more widely read—began as a mineralogist. W.G. Archer and M.S. Randhawa—who inspired Goswamy's interest in Pahari painting—were civil servants. Archer served in the ICS in Bihar and Randhawa was a lifelong bureaucrat.

Indeed, Goswamy initially followed suit: he joined the IAS (1956 cadre) and served two years in Gaya before returning to Panjab University. There he studied not art history (not yet available) but history. He had read Randhawa's *Kangra Valley Painting*. But he had also read the English historian G.M. Trevelyan—a gifted story-teller who examined the social life and



CONVERSATIONS
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identity of a nation. Bringing together these two points—hitherto poles apart—Goswamy decided to investigate the social conditions in which Pahari painting emerged. His professors doubted it could be done, so Goswamy challenged them to consult the experts. Write to Archer, he told them; write to A.L. Basham at SOAS, write to Karl Khandalavala. They did, and all three wrote back and said: Good idea, let him have a go.

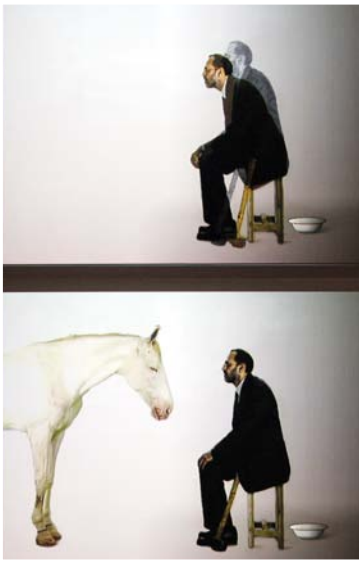
Thus the main course of his research was set from the start, leading to his most distinctive contributions. But it led him into trouble too. His early encounters with Archer were warm and friendly. He first met him in London in 1962, after Archer had examined his thesis. Thereafter he was a regular guest at the Archers' house, and Goswamy helped W.G. to decipher inscriptions in Takri, the script of the hills. Archer still often visited Punjab too, gathering data for his magnum opus, *Indian Paintings from the Punjab Hills* (1973).

Even before that book was published, Goswamy's own first major work, *Family as the Basis of Style* (1968), undermined the elaborate but fragile architecture of Archer's regional definitions. It looked as though the factual minutiae of social history were blasting a hole in the time-honoured practice of stylistic analysis. It is more to Archer's discredit than Goswamy's that this difference in approach led to their falling out. And Randhawa—friend and disciple to Archer—was even less forgiving. Goswamy's note on Archer—written long after the latter's death—fondly recalls their early friendship. He writes less about Randhawa, though he justly credits him with inaugurating a 'museums movement' in Punjab.

Another formative influence was Mulk Raj Anand, for a while Tagore Professor at Panjab University. Goswamy feels Anand's foreign exposure made him a misfit in his own country. But he was fiery, engagingly argumentative, and could make people excited about art. *'Ajeeb aadmi tha woh'*, he says, borrowing a famous line. Sure, but despite all that he wrote about art, Anand was not primarily an art historian. Perhaps you can't pigeonhole a polymath, but he was foremost a novelist.

So between Anand and Trevelyan, we have some likely sources of Goswamy's passion and prose style. But where did the art historical discipline come from, since it wasn't the classroom? Perhaps in part from another encounter: with Karl Khandalavala, that 'thorough gentleman', with whom Goswamy sat on museum acquisitions committees in the 1970s. He observed his unerring eye, and how he allowed art to speak to him. Close scrutiny is the key. Art history is a discipline, according to Goswamy, because it teaches you to 'visually enter a work of art'. ■

–Giles Tillotson



20th

Century Indian Art is one of those sumptuously produced Thames & Hudson tomes that you immediately want to steal from the bookshop, its size and heft presenting a daunting challenge to any booklifter working alone and without an oversize satchel or backpack.

The volume fills a much-needed gap. One may or may not have felt the absence of a comprehensive overview of modern and contemporary Indian art but, now that it is here, you wonder what took so long and how those interested in the subject managed without such a critical compendium. As the introduction tells us, the book 'tells the story of Indian artists' responses to artistic modernity as part of a global phenomenon...', addressing the question: '...what does Indian modernism share with other modernisms, and in what way does it offer a unique vision of modernity?'

While the sharpest focus is on Indian art in the 20th century, the deep depth of field actually catches roughly the last 140 years of visual and plastic art production in the subcontinent, with